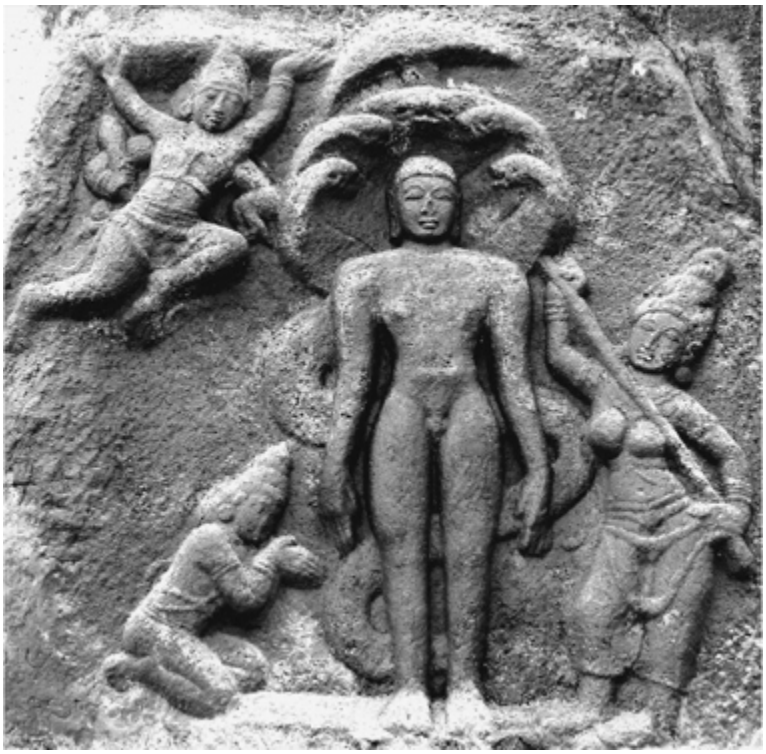


One of four Jain images of uncertain date carved on the four sides of a 7-metre-high standing stone at Thirakoil, north of Tellar in Tamil Nadu. It shows the Naga snake-king Dharanendra protecting with his hoods the 23rd Jain tirthankara (‘ford-crosser’) Parshvanath from storm clouds sent by his enemy the cloud deity Samvara, with his queen Padmavati also holding an umbrella.

The same test can be applied to flora as to fauna – for example, to the soma plant. The *R-V* devotes no fewer than 123 hymns to the sacred soma, as indeed does the Avesta. This was some form of still unidentified vine the juice of which was distilled and drunk as part of a hugely important life-conferring ritual and may possibly have contained a psychoactive substance. The older books of the *R-V* make constant allusions to soma drinking but over time the ritual loses its importance, to the point where soma ceases to be an elixir and becomes a moon-god, also known as Chandra. The inference has to be that the soma vine was no longer available in the plains of the Punjab.

By contrast, the sacred *tulasi* or tulsi plant (basil) today occupies a very special place in every Hindu household as a